



DAVIE HINSHAW/Staff

Earl Simpson holds baby owl roused from the Union County farmer's soybean silo.

Whooo! That was scary

Young owls frightened into premature flight

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NEW SALEM — As first flights go, it wasn't that bad — until the tractor-trailer got in the way.

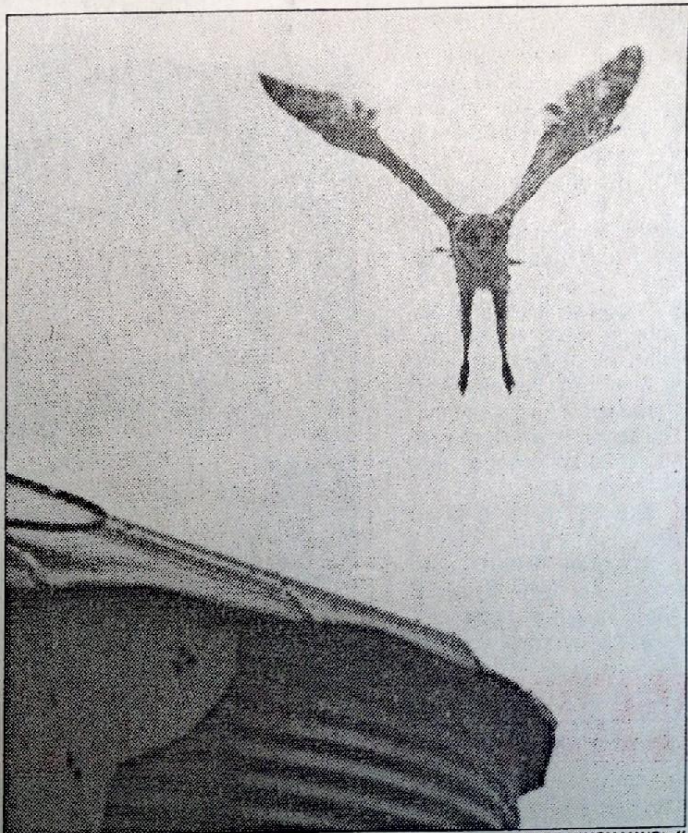
A barn owlet took to the air prematurely last week when the bird was roused from its home — a domicile doubling as Earl Simpson's soybean silo. The maiden voyage ended 10 yards later when the baby owl careened head first into a tractor-trailer.

It's spring again, and young birds are testing their wings and occasionally colliding with humanity. This time, the owlet and its siblings belonged to a protected species with dwindling numbers. And the birds happened to be born in the way of a farmer's job.

Moments before the grain was to be drained from the Union County silo, three people descended inside hoping to coax the owlet and its four siblings into a coop. But the courageous youngster darted out of the silo and into the air.

Not a wise move.

After a somewhat troubled flight pattern, the baby owl, which does not have its permanent feathers



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First flight: One of the five owlets tests its wings before being transported to the Carolina Raptor Center in Mecklenburg.

Young owls survive scary flights

Whoood!

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yet, met the trailer in a most unfriendly manner. The owlet slid to the ground, tried to shake off the unfriendly jolt, and then cowered under a trailer wheel.

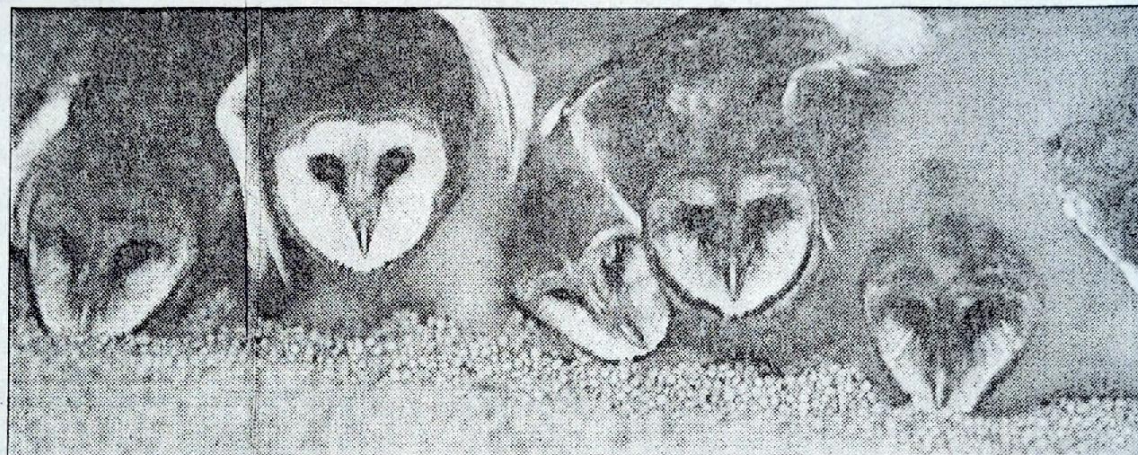
Moments later, another owlet attempted a similar aeronautical maneuver. This youngster had a much better time of it, but experienced the shock of a crash landing. The bird hobbled into a field.

Not exactly the maiden flights the birds had dreamed of, but hey, even Orville and Wilbur Wright didn't fly exactly as they planned their first time out.

Both birds were quickly snatched up by Simpson. The remaining three were rescued in the silo by Simpson's son Alvin, Derrick Austin, a neighbor, and Danny Brigman, a wildlife enforcement officer. All five owlets were transported to the Carolina Raptor Center in Mecklenburg County.

Mom and Dad Owl never showed up.

Deborah Sue Griffin, education director for the center, said the youngsters are doing fine and will live in a rehabilitation unit with a



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Baby owls huddle at top of grain bin filled with soybeans.

"foster" barn owl. She said the five likely will be freed within four to six weeks.

The barn owl is a protected species whose numbers have dropped drastically during the past few years, Griffin said. Silos and barns are popular roosting and nesting places, but since many of the older structures have been taken down, the barn owl is considered a species of special concern, Griffin said.

Earl Simpson discovered the baby owls a few weeks ago when he noticed two older owls circling the silo.

"They were acting concerned, so I guessed there might be something in the silo that did not belong," Simpson said. "We opened it up and there they were — five baby barn owls. Sure was a surprise."

Simpson left the youngsters alone, hoping they would mature and vacate the premises before he needed to empty the silo. Unfortunately, economics dictated that the birds had to leave Thursday morning, before they were fully fledged.

To say the least, the owlets were not exactly pleased when their

home was invaded. When Brigman, Simpson and Austin descended into the bin, the owlets arched their backs and let out a gravelly hiss.

After the two loudest owlets darted out, the remaining three allowed a net to be thrown over them.

Griffin said once the birds are old enough, they will be set loose at Simpson's farm, "if he will allow it."

The unwitting foster dad said he's willing to share his land.

"Love to have them back," Simpson said.